Chapter 2.

FOREIGN POLICY AND YOU

Making a Difference in Your Daily Life

India may matter to the world and vice versa. But that does not mean we Indians should not watch out for ourselves. From that national perspective, what is a ‘good’ foreign policy? Perhaps we over-complicate the answer by confusing sensible pursuit of interests with complicated formulations. So, it is important to look beyond the terminology and validate it through gut answers.

A ‘good’ foreign policy must work for you personally. Your everyday needs from the world must be better met. Since we are a collective as a country, our national security must be ensured. As that is done, the pursuit of our aspirations must be facilitated. Foreign policy, being the link to the outside, should enable us to draw what we seek. It could be technology, capital, best practices or work opportunities. And obviously, we would all like to be strong, look good and feel appreciated.

In the final analysis, good foreign policy must read global trends well and anticipate what portends for our nation and our people. When the unexpected happens, it must respond nimbly and effectively. At the same time, it must message our intentions and project our image positively. Any effort that ensures these goals has a lot going for it. It does not necessarily need to sound nice; it must simply pass the smell test.

Put yourself in the shoes of an Indian student who happened to be in Ukraine on 24 February 2022. Focussed on educational prospects, you are now caught in the middle of a serious conflict. It is not just you and thousands more of your fellow nationals, there are millions of Ukrainians who are trying to get out of the country at the same time. Internal travel is dangerous and complicated. The borders are even more so due to overcrowding and congestion. In the conflict-impacted cities, there is even